IMPROVE YOUR VIDEO PLAYBACK

Despite the convenience of codec packs and le ole' trusty VLC, everyone's had their share of days when they've felt their videos to be stuttering too much, the colours look a tad too washed out or there's too much pixelation. Fortunately, most DirectShow players and decoding filters are versatile and can be customised to suit one's needs – be it to speed up laggy videos or to improve visual fidelity at the cost of putting their CPUs under some more load. This article will mostly contain examples from Media Player Classic – Home cinema or ffdshow, but these changes can also be made on, or could affect, any half-way decent video player software because they're built around ffdshow or libavcodec anyway.

Original

Enhanced

Queue output samples

This neat option is rather inexplicably disabled by default on ffdshow. When enabled, it allows the CPU to immediately move onto the next frame when it's done processing one, instead of wasting cycles like it does on default behaviour. It's most likely to be useful when you're experiencing lag in "heavy" scenes, but not throughout the video. To enable this option, open up the ffdshow video decoder configuration (usually at `Start > Program Files/All Programs > ffdshow > ffdshow video decoder configuration`) and go to the option named "Queue & misc". Check "Queue Output Samples" and "Enable queue in VMR9-YV12" and uncheck "Use Queue only in:", unless you run into compatibility issues

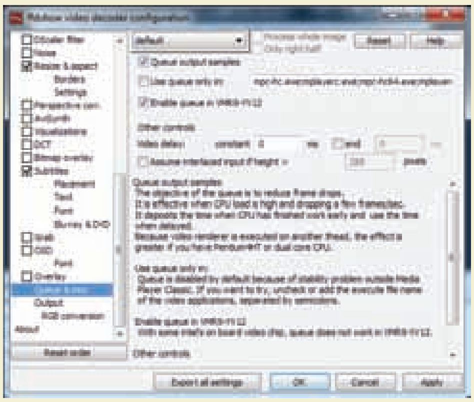
Enable DXVA

Most modern day video cards now support partial or even complete video decoding, so if for some reason your CPU is struggling and you have a PureVideo compatible NVIDIA card or an AVIVO compatible ATI/AMD card, you can offload your video processing to the GPU and improve performance that way. You'll need to go to Media Player Classic – Home Cinema's Internal Filters screen and disable FFMpeg decoding of H264, VC-1 and MPEG2 video so your graphics card can take over. Once you've done that, double click on the filters that have DXVA in brackets and set the decoder to "Skip all checks" for NVIDIA cards and "Full checks" for ATI/AMD cards. You'll also need to select a compatible renderer, more on that coming up.

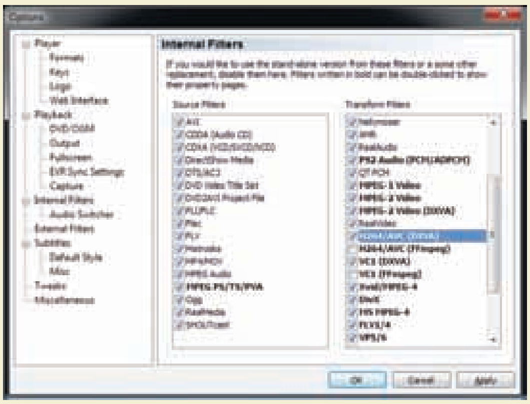
If you have CoreAVC installed and an NVIDIA card, you can also take advantage of your GPU's CUDA processing for performance boosts.

Pick a good renderer

Most Video Players default to the Overlay method of rendering video, which while decent in quality is not the best on offer. Much better options include VMR9, which uses D3D9, or if you're on Vista or Windows 7, Enhanced Video



Queuing output samples, improve performance



How to enable DXVA on MPC-HC